

HORS D'OEUVRES | DILIP BOBB

The Reality Cheque



I have a neighbour who is a pain in the rear and also the ear. He is a bachelor who throws frequent parties where the decibel level of his guests and his music system would wake the dead, never mind the living. The last two months have been bliss. Rock On! has given way to the sounds of silence. He's been affected, like most of humanity, by the economic downturn. In a larger sense, it's an important metaphor for what is the biggest life-changing event in generations: the economic meltdown. It's cruel, it's frightening, tragic and a great leveller, but amid the doom and gloom are emerging some hidden positives.

My recently silenced neighbour was a sub prime example of the excess that had become addictive in urban India. The wealth induced by India's economic growth had made us all a little crazy and a little unrealistic. Armed with a fistful of credit cards we mortgaged our lives, our souls and our future. Savings were sacrificed for keeping up with the Jainses. Tomorrow would never come because we were all too busy celebrating today. Weddings became the ultimate test of our financial and social credibility, the ultimate excess, with parents plunged happily, and heavily, into debt, to showcase their extravagance on events that lasted a week or more. Incredible India had become Insatiable India.

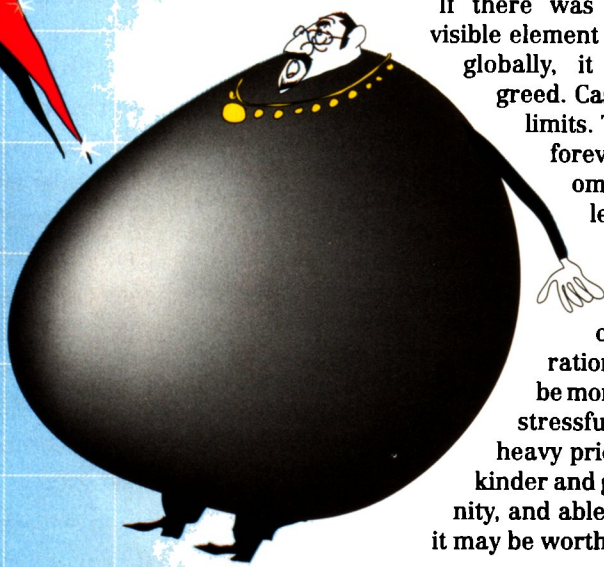
It was surreal, how much artifice and overkill had entered our lives. Now, we have a reality check, or cheque, and it's starting to restore some sanity. The crisis has made everyone careful and certainly saner. Extravagance is out, rationality is in. There are other silver linings. I know a guy who used to be out every night; clubs, pubs or parties, life was one endless binge. His wife and

kids hardly saw him and the chasm was becoming unbridgeable. He is a stockbroker and he's mostly at home now, rediscovering the joys of family, reconnecting with his kids and his wife and other friends he'd lost touch with.

There are countless examples of individuals and couples who have sobered up because of the economy but more importantly, will never return to their wanton ways. It's been painful awakening but it will perforce, be permanent.

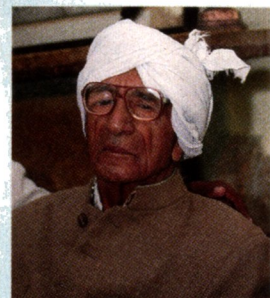
If there was one common and visible element in society, here and globally, it was Satyam-style greed. Cash and flash had no limits. That era has ended, forever. Even if the economy recovers, the lessons from the crisis are painful but obvious. Our cars will be greener, our needs more rational and our lives will be more satisfying and less stressful. We may pay a heavy price but if we emerge kinder and gentler as a community, and able to smell the coffee, it may be worth the hangover.

SAURABH SINGH



SIGNPOSTS

DIED: **Ranbir Singh Hooda**, 95, former parliamentarian and the lone surviving member of the Constitutional Assembly. He was the father of Haryana Chief Minister Bhopinder Singh Hooda.



THE ECONOMIC DOWNTURN HAS MADE EVERYONE CAREFUL AND CERTAINLY SANER.

ARRESTED: R&AW officer **A.S. Narayan Rao** by the CBI for allegedly taking a bribe of Rs 1 lakh from a Chennai-based manufacturer.

DIED: Journalist and writer **Chandrakant Kaul** with Goa's first Konkani daily *Sunaparant*. He received the Sahitya Academy award for his novel *Vhakal Panni*.

APPOINTED: Rear Admiral **Sudhir Pillal** as the Flag Officer Goa Area and Flag Officer Naval Aviation. He has flown over 3,000 hours on naval aircraft and has commanded the Naval Air Station INS *Garuda* at Kochi.

